

Area of Study 3B – Christianity

Overview

This area of study comprises a study in depth of Christianity as a lived religion within the United Kingdom and throughout the world, and its beliefs and teachings on life, specifically about Philosophy of Religion and issues of equality and social justice.

There are four sections: Christian Beliefs, Philosophy of Religion, Living the Christian Life and Equality.

The significance and importance of the various beliefs, issues and practices to Christians today should be explored throughout the sections. This should include reference to how the Bible informs a Christian's understanding of the topics and how approaches to the issues are underpinned by philosophical arguments and ethical theory as applicable.

Students will be expected to study Christianity within the context of the wider British society, the religious traditions of which are, in the main, Christian. Students should recognise that Christianity is one of the many religions and world views in Great Britain, which include Buddhism, Hinduism, Islam, Judaism, Sikhism and non-religious views such as Humanism and atheism. This knowledge may be applied throughout the assessment of the specified content.

Students should compare and contrast two areas of belief and practice within Christianity with one of either Buddhism, Hinduism, Islam, Judaism, or Sikhism:

- Beliefs about the afterlife and their significance (1.6)*
- The practice and significance of worship (3.1)*

Students should compare and contrast the areas of ethics and/or philosophy within Christianity with non-religious views as outlined in the content below.

Students should also recognise that within Christianity there may be more than one perspective in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed. Common and divergent views within Christianity in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed should be included throughout, including reference to Catholic, Orthodox, Protestant and other Christian traditions.

Students should have an understanding of:

1.1	The Trinity: the nature and significance of the Trinity as expressed in the Nicene Creed; the nature and significance of the oneness of God; the nature and significance of each of the Persons individually: including reference to Matthew 3:13–17; how this is reflected in Christian worship and belief today.
1.2	The creation of the universe and of humanity: the biblical account of creation and divergent ways in which it may be understood by Christians, including as literal and metaphorical; the role of the Word and Spirit in creation, including John 1:1–18 and Genesis 1–3; the importance of creation for Christians today.
1.3	The Incarnation: the nature and importance of the person of Jesus Christ as the incarnate Son of God; the biblical basis of this teaching, including John 1:1–18 and 1 Timothy 3:16 and its significance for Christians today.
1.4	The last days of Jesus' life: the Last Supper, betrayal, arrest, trial, crucifixion, resurrection and ascension of Jesus; the accounts of these within the Bible, including Luke 22–24 and the significance of these events to understanding the person of Jesus Christ.
1.5	The nature and significance of salvation and the role of Christ within salvation: law, sin, grace and Spirit, the role of Christ in salvation, including John 3:10–21 and Acts 4:8–12; the nature and significance of atonement within Christianity and its link to salvation.
1.6*	Christian eschatology: divergent Christian teachings about life after death, including the nature and significance of resurrection, judgement, heaven, and hell and purgatory, with reference to the 39 Articles of Religion and Catholic teachings; how beliefs about life after death are shown in the Bible, including reference to 2 Corinthians 5:1–10 and divergent understandings as to why they are important for Christians today.
1.7	The problem of evil/suffering and a loving and righteous God: the problems it raises for Christians about the nature of God, including reference to omnipotence and benevolence, including Psalm 103; how the problem may cause believers to question their faith or the existence of God; the nature and examples of natural suffering, moral suffering.
1.8	Divergent solutions offered to the problem of evil/suffering and a loving and righteous God: biblical, theoretical and practical, including reference to Psalm 119, Job, free will, vale of soul-making, prayer, and charity; the success of solutions to the problem.

Students should have an understanding of:

2.1	Revelation as proof of the existence of God; revelation as shown in the Bible, including in the covenants with Noah and Abraham, and through Jesus, including Hebrews 1:1–4; divergent understandings of what revelation shows about the nature of God for Christians.
2.2	Visions as proof of the existence of God: the nature and importance of visions for Christians; biblical and non-biblical examples of visions, including Genesis 15 and Matthew 17:1–13; reasons why they might lead to belief in the existence of God and Christian responses to non-religious arguments (including atheist and Humanist) which maintain that visions are hallucinations and provide no proof that God exists; divergent understandings of what visions show about the nature of God for Christians.
2.3	Miracles as proof of the existence of God: the nature and importance of miracles for Christians; biblical examples of miracles, including John 4:43–54; reasons why they might lead to belief in the existence of God and Christian responses to non-religious arguments (including atheist and Humanist) which maintain that miracles can be scientifically explained and provide no proof that God exists; divergent understandings of what miracles show about the nature of God for Christians.
2.4	Christian attitudes towards religious experiences and their use as philosophical arguments for the existence of God: the nature of a religious experience and why it might be regarded as revelation, including reference to Exodus 3; Christian responses to non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) arguments that religious experiences do not provide proof that God exists.
2.5	Christian teaching about prayers: Christian teachings about the nature and importance of prayers; Christian teachings about reasons prayers that are answered in the way the person expects might lead to belief in God, including 1 John 5:13–17.
2.6	Design argument: the classical design argument for the existence of God and its use by Christians as a philosophical argument for the existence of God; divergent understandings about what the design argument may show about the nature of God for Christians, including Romans 1:18–24; Christian responses to non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) arguments against the design argument as evidence for the existence of God.
2.7	Cosmological argument: the cosmological argument for the existence of God and its use by Christians as a philosophical argument for the existence of God; divergent understandings about what the cosmological argument shows about the nature of God for Christians, including Thomas Aquinas' First Three Ways of showing God's existence; Christian responses to non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) arguments against the cosmological argument as evidence for the existence of God.
2.8	Religious upbringing: Christian teachings about raising children to believe in God, including reference to Proverbs 22:6; features of a Christian upbringing and why they may lead to belief in God; Christian responses to non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) arguments about why a religious upbringing may result in a rejection of God's existence.

Students should have an understanding of:

3.1*	Christian worship: liturgical and non-liturgical forms of worship, including activities which are informal and individual, including reference to the <i>Book of Common Prayer</i> ; when each form might be used and why; divergent Christian attitudes towards the practices, meaning and significance of liturgical and non-liturgical forms of worship in Christian life today, with reference to denominations who worship with less structure such as some Pentecostal churches.
3.2	The role of the sacraments in Christian life and their practice in two denominations: the role of the sacraments/ordinance as a whole; the nature and importance of the meaning and celebration of baptism and the Eucharist in at least two denominations, including reference to the 39 Articles XXV–XXXVI; divergent Christian attitudes towards the use and number of sacraments in Orthodox, Catholic and Protestant traditions.
3.3	The nature and purpose of prayer: the nature of and examples of the different types of prayer; set prayers; informal prayer and the Lord's Prayer, including Matthew 6:5–14; when each type might be used and why; divergent Christian attitudes towards the importance of each type of prayer for Christians today.
3.4	Pilgrimage: the nature, history and purpose of pilgrimage, including interpretations Luke 2:41–43; the significance of the places people go on pilgrimage; divergent Christian teachings about whether pilgrimage is important for Christians today, with specific reference to Catholic and Protestant understandings; the activities associated with, and significance of, Jerusalem, Iona, Taizé and Walsingham.
3.5	Christian religious celebrations: the nature and history of Christian festivals in the church year, including Christmas and Easter; the significance of celebrating Advent and Christmas; the significance of celebrating Holy Week and Easter with reference to interpretations of 1 Corinthians 15:12–34.
3.6	The future of the Christian Church: Church growth, the history and purpose of missionary and evangelical work, including reference to Mark 16:9–20 and John 20:21–22; divergent ways this is put into practice by the Church locally, nationally and globally; Christian attitudes to why evangelical work is important for the Church and for individual Christians.
3.7	The role and importance of the local church in the local community: how and why it helps the individual believer and the local area; local parish activities, including interpretations of 1 Peter 5:1–4, ecumenism, outreach work, the centre of Christian identity and worship through living practices.
3.8	The role and importance of the Church in the worldwide community: how and why it works for reconciliation and the problems faced by the persecuted Church; divergent Christian responses to teachings about charity, including 1 Corinthians 13 and Matthew 25:31–46; the work of Christian Aid, what it does and why.

Students should have an understanding of:

4.1	Christian teaching on human rights: Christian teachings and responses to the nature, history and purpose of human rights; the importance of human rights and why Christians might support them, including Proverbs 14:31; divergent Christian responses to the need for and application of individual human rights, including the support offered by situation ethics; Christian responses to non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) arguments about human rights.
4.2	Christian attitudes towards equality: Christian teachings, responses and solutions to the causes of inequality and problems caused by inequality in the world; Christian teaching about equality, including Galatians 3:23–29.
4.3	Christian attitudes towards religious freedom: Christian teachings and responses to the nature of religious freedom, including reference to the Catechism of the Catholic Church 1738 and 1747; the response of the Church to a multi-faith society; the benefits and challenges for Christians living in a multi-faith society; Christian responses to non-religious arguments (including atheist and Humanist) against aspects of religious freedom.
4.4	Christian attitudes to prejudice and discrimination: Christian teachings and responses to the nature of prejudice and discrimination and the problems they cause; Christian teachings on why prejudice and discrimination against religions is wrong, including reference to Galatians 2:1–10.
4.5	Christian attitudes towards racial harmony: Christian teachings and responses to racial harmony including interpretations of John 13:34, including links to situation ethics; how and why Christians have worked for racial harmony, including the work and teachings of Desmond Tutu; the benefits for Christians of living in a multi-ethnic society.
4.6	Christian attitudes towards racial discrimination: Christian teachings and responses to racial discrimination, how and why racial discrimination causes problems in society, including Acts 17:22–28.
4.7	Christian attitudes to social justice: Christian teachings and responses to the nature and history of the distribution of wealth and opportunity in the UK and the world; Christian teaching about social justice, including reference to Matthew 25:31–46, and the way the Church works for social justice, including links to situation ethics.
4.8	Christian attitudes towards wealth and poverty: Christian teachings and responses to the nature and causes of poverty in the UK and in the world including absolute and relative; Christian teachings about wealth and poverty, including biblical examples such as Matthew 25:31–47 and links to virtue ethics.